The Marketing Engineer's Toolkit

APIs, MCP, Agents, and the Building Blocks Behind Your AI Stack

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BEFORE WE START

Nice to meet you! I’m Erica.

Operator first. 9 years teaching AI, 7 years running an AI company, and a career spent career spent scaling growth.



1,200+	Clients served, leading a 40-person team at the the largest agency in the Gulf South
0 → 300+	Clients: scaled rasa.io as COO
5x	AI learners as CMO of Sidecar.ai
300+	Talks, trainings, and sessions on AI
GrowthHubAI	AI growth firm: Erica Salm Rench LLC, the AI Growth Agency

What we will cover today

01

Your AI stack

What surrounds the model

02

Context

What AI knows and how it works

03

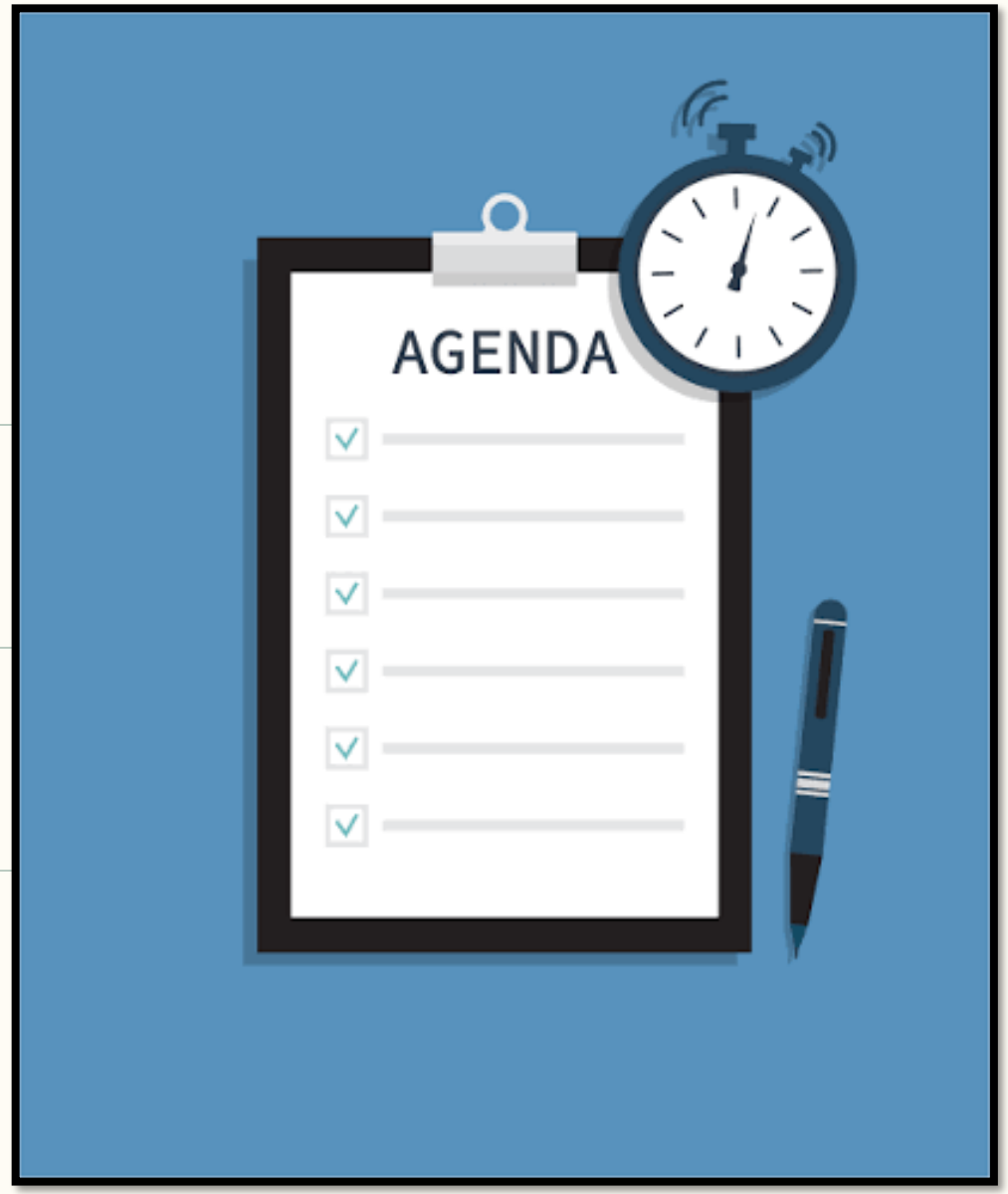
MCP, APIs, Agents, Skills, RAG, Memory

Next level context and real changes

04

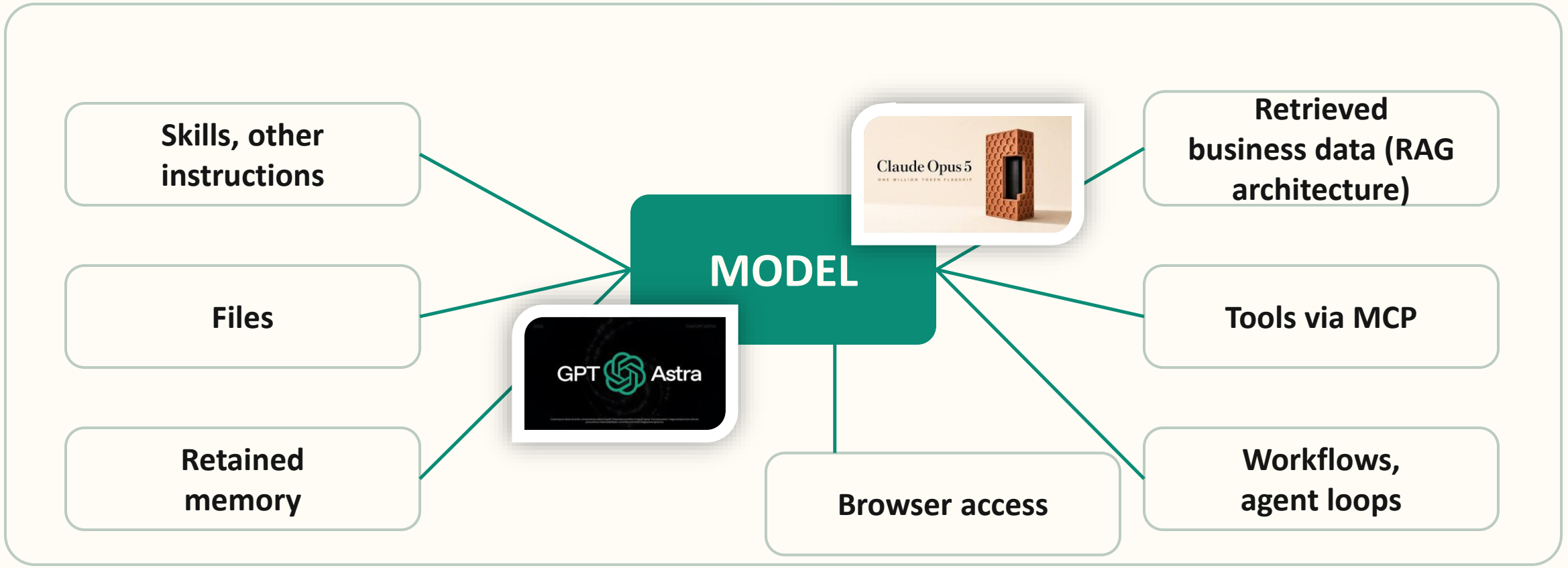
My operations, live

A first workflow you can build



The model sits inside a larger system

AI APPLICATION



It is a brain in a box, and it needs context infrastructure to work (well).

AI × GROWTH OPS

Context is Queen.

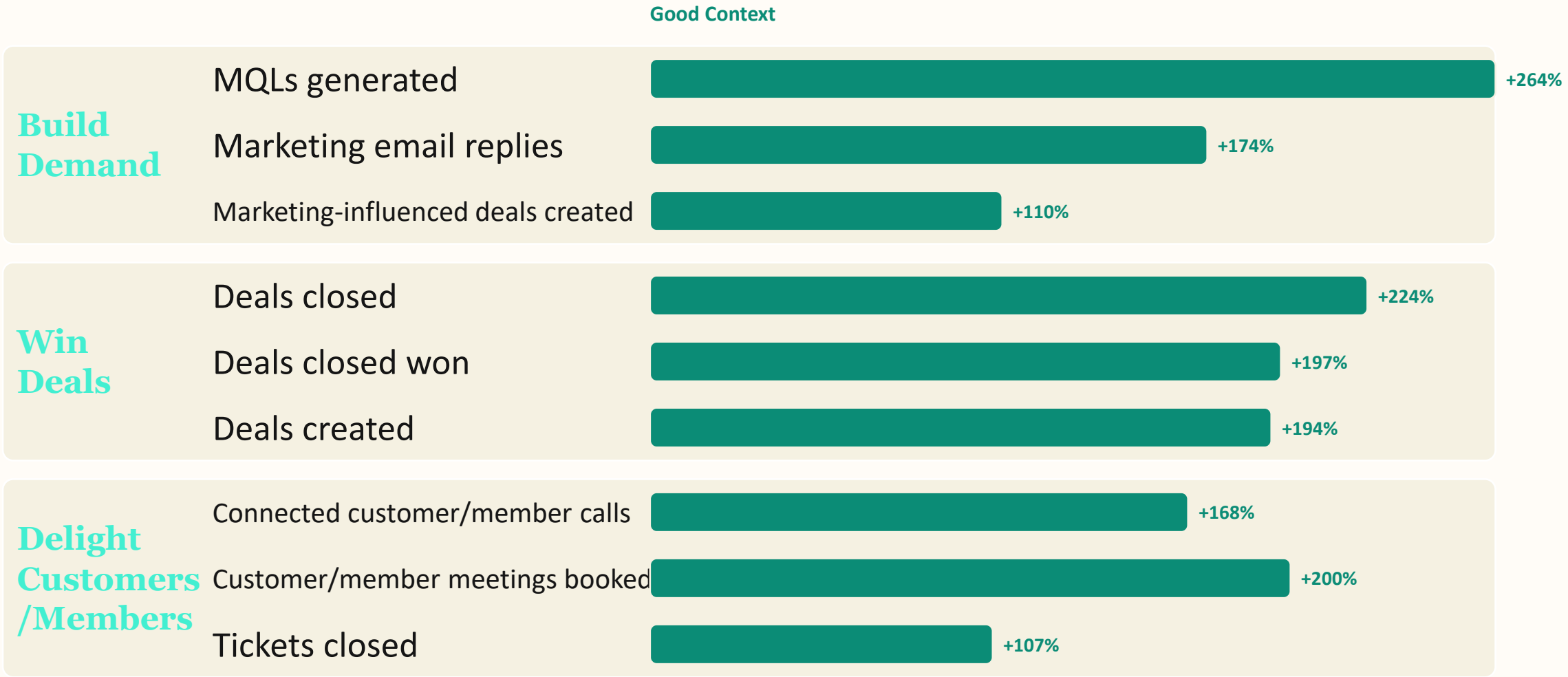


One prompt.
An entire campaign.

- Emails
- Landing page
- Copy
- Audience segment

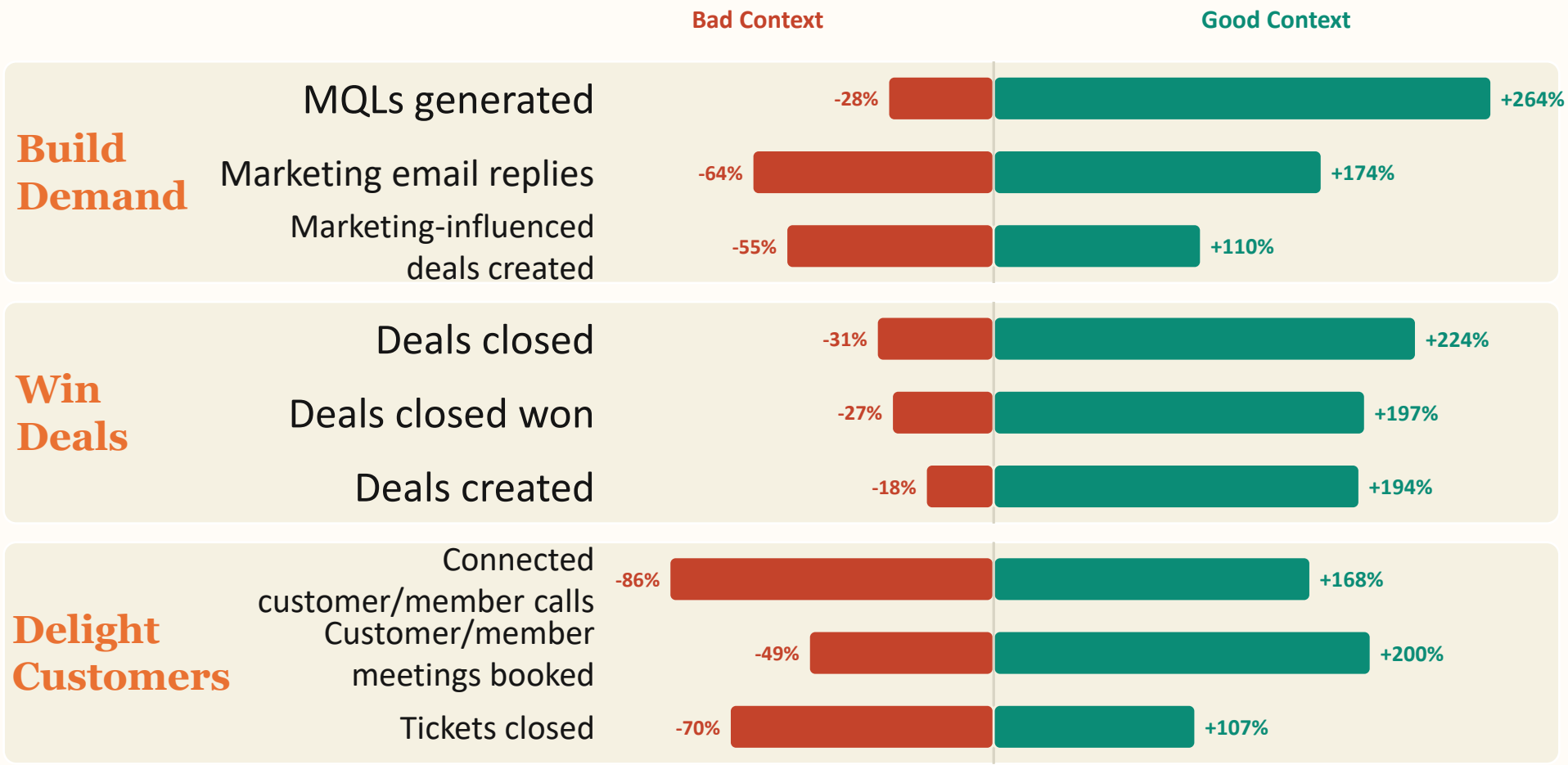
rowth
ubAI.ai
MAICON
Marketing Artificial Intelligence Conference

Good context delivers great outcomes



Source: HubSpot customer usage data, May 2026

Bad context is worse than no AI



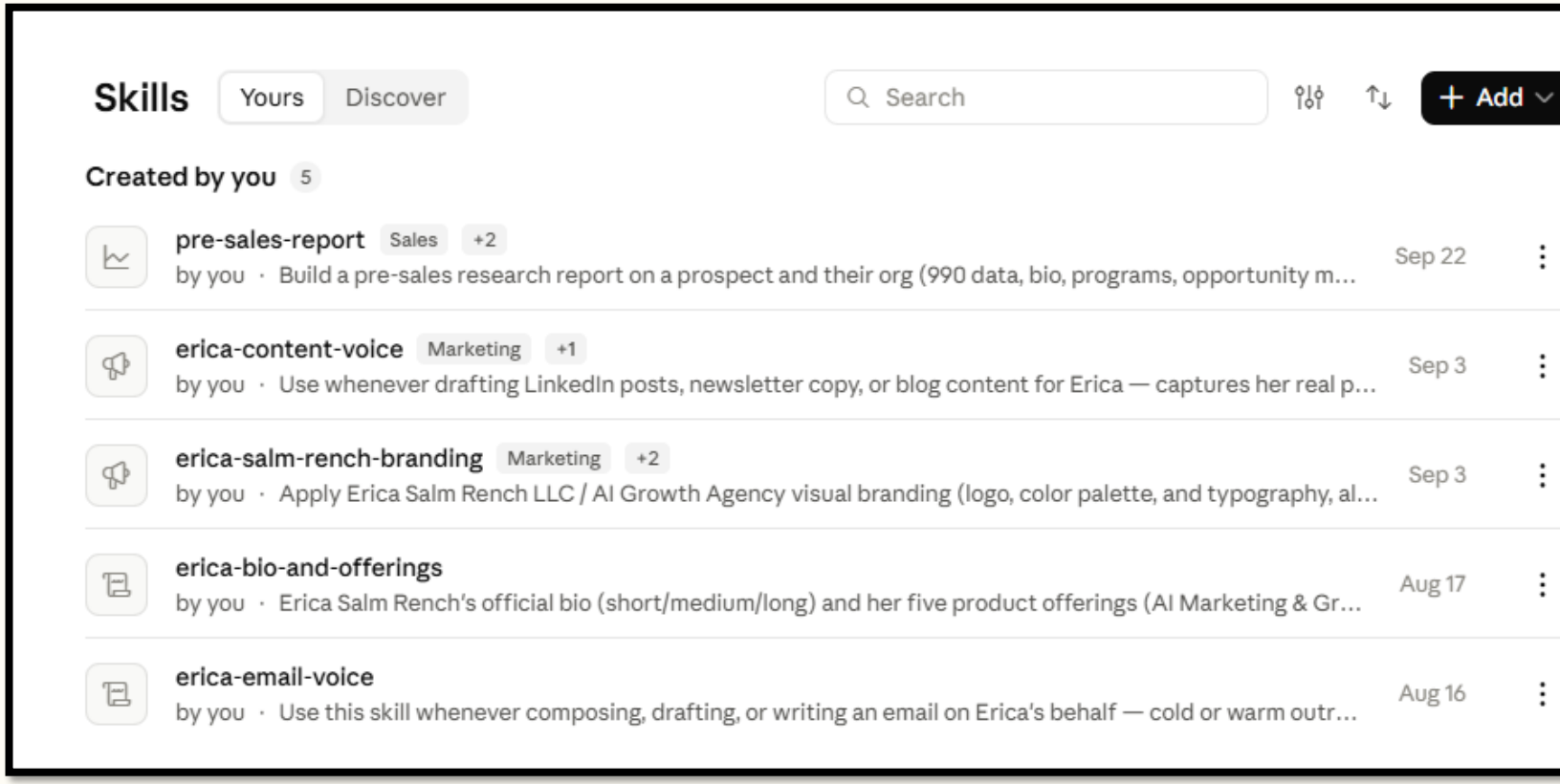
Source: HubSpot customer usage data, May 2026

A skill packages a playbook for the app or agent

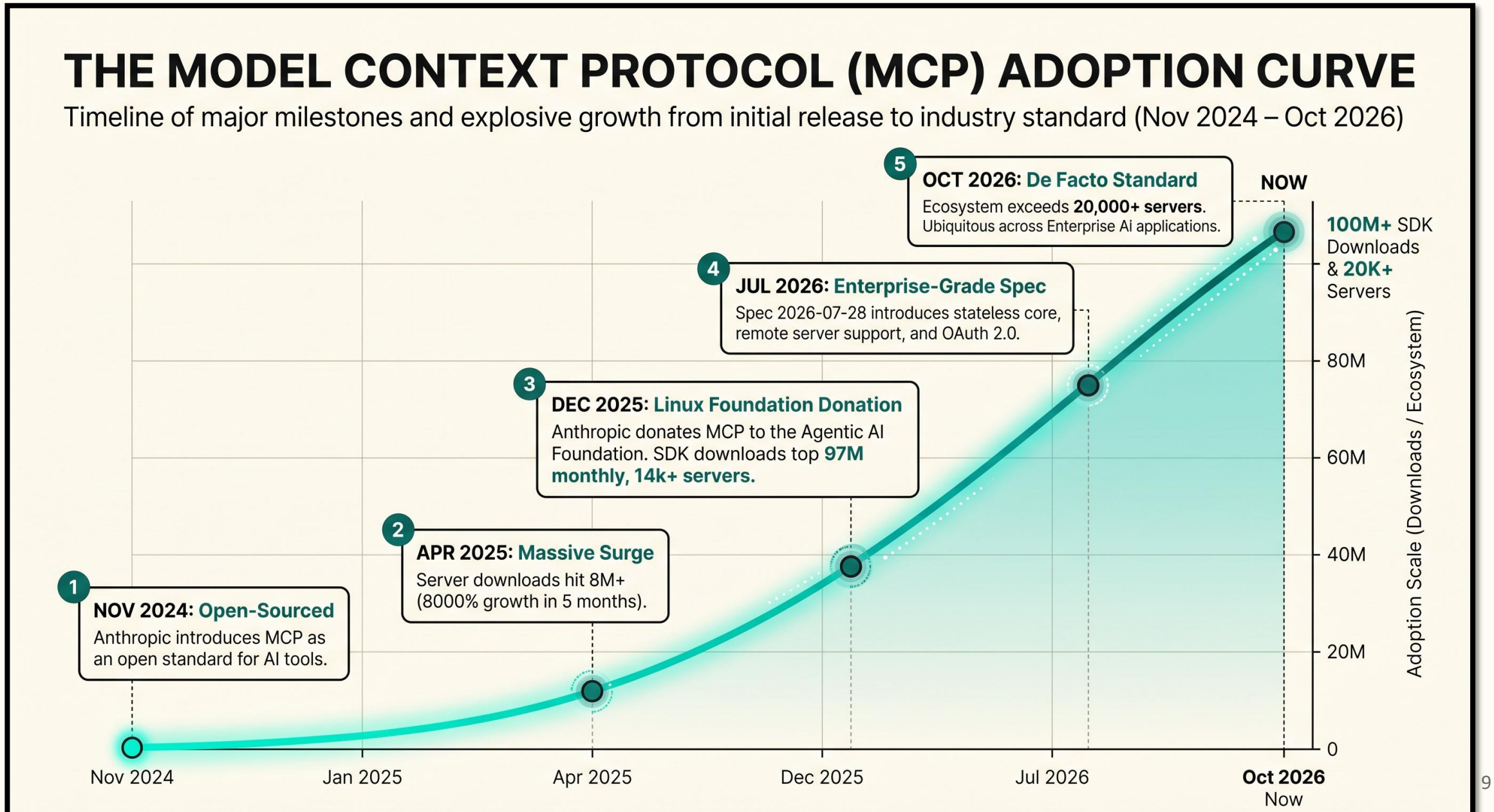
A skill is your best person's process, written once so AI can follow it every time.

- **Loads only when it's relevant**
- **Shared, not siloed**
- **Portable and editable**



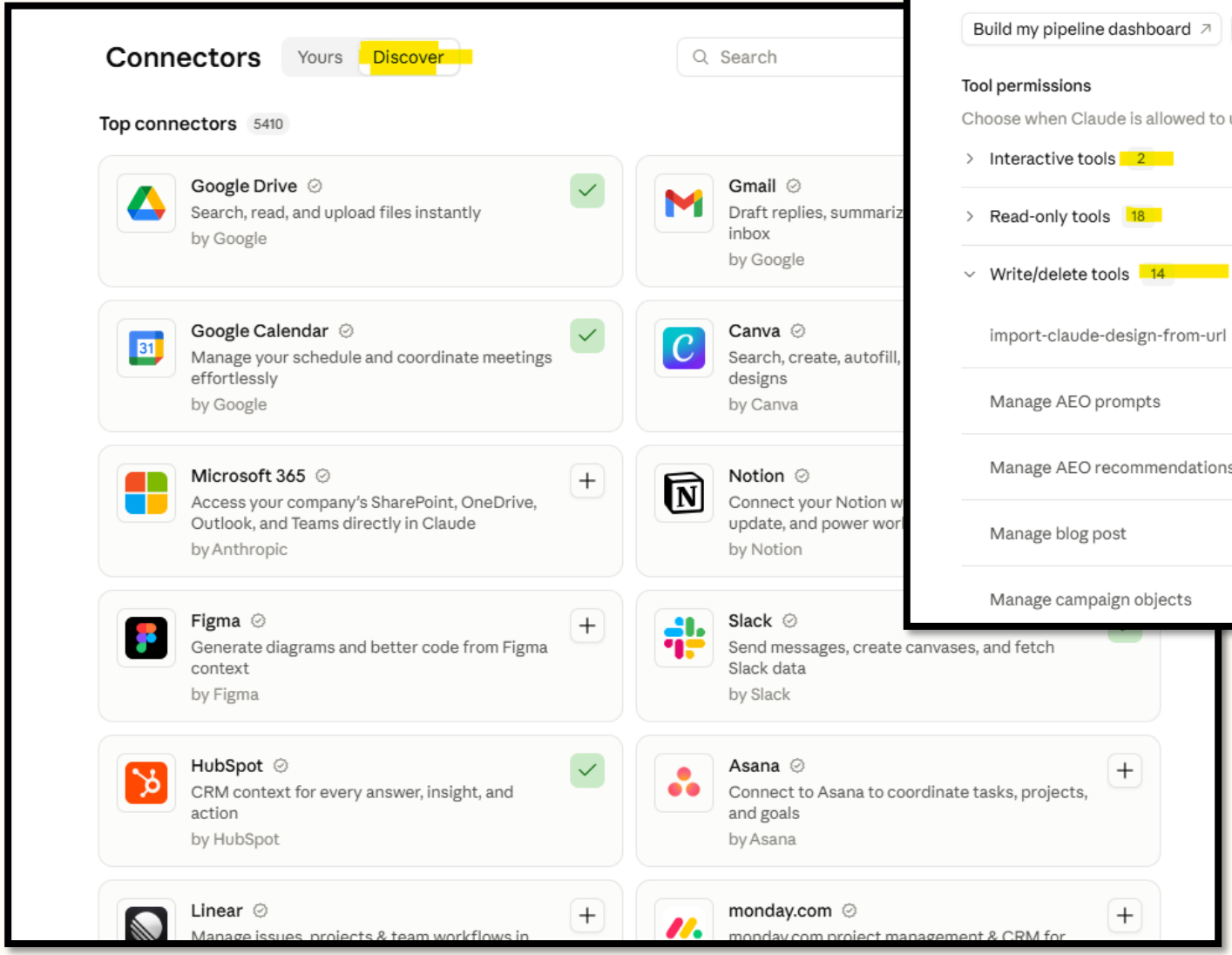


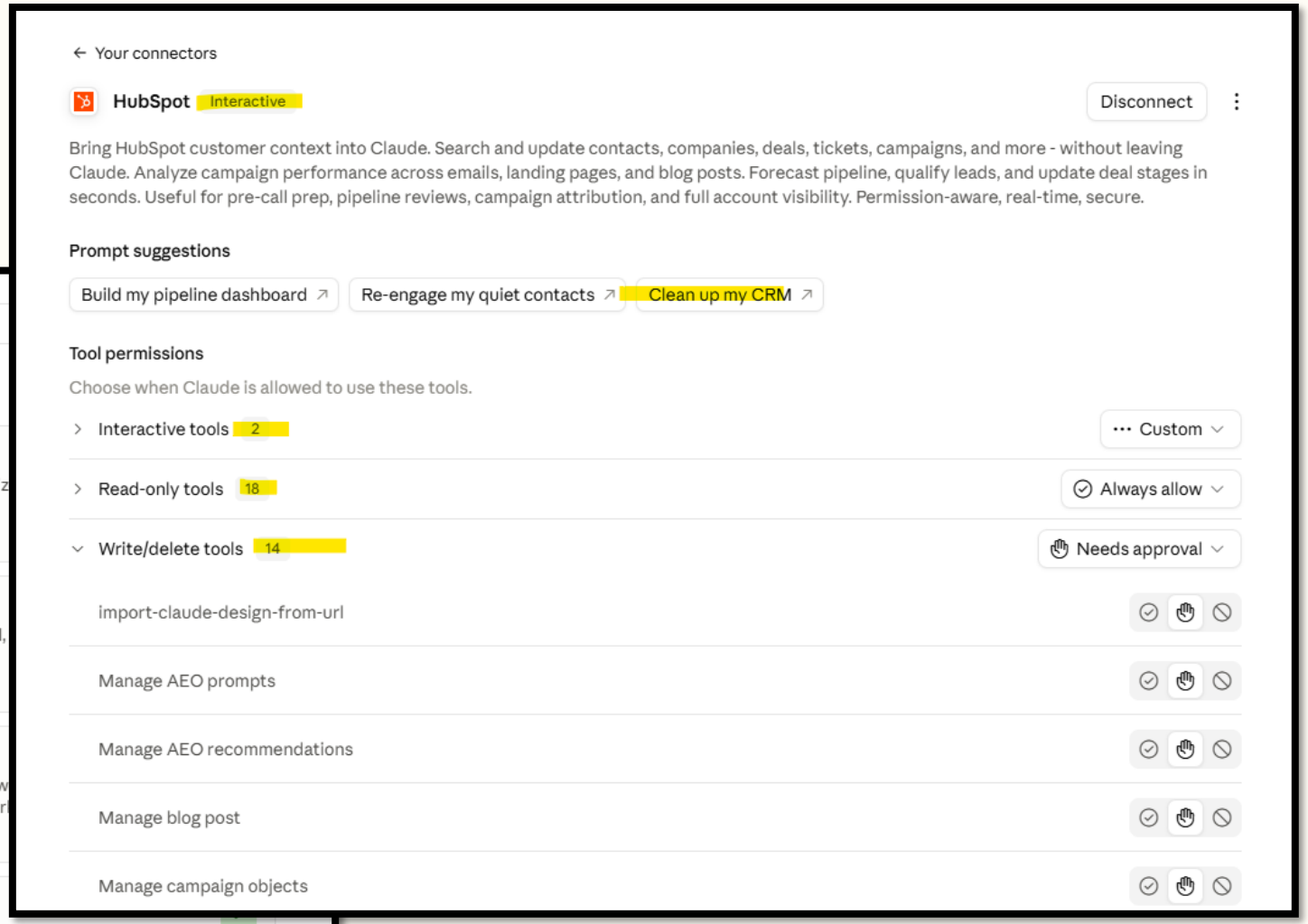
MCP quickly became a shared connection standard



Model Context Protocol

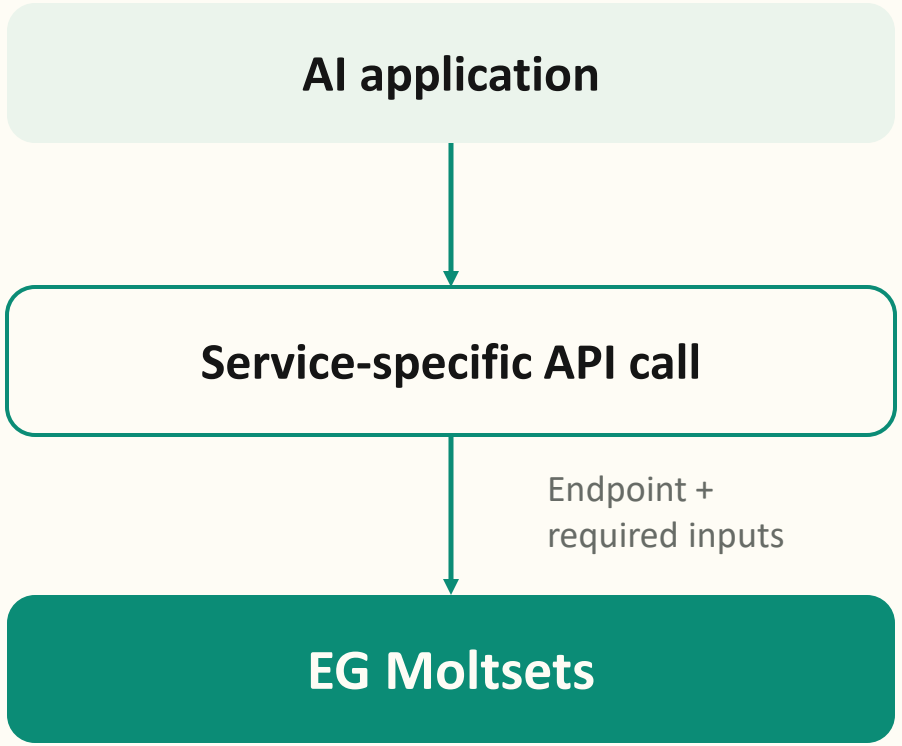
Look at MCP Functionality to Assess Tools



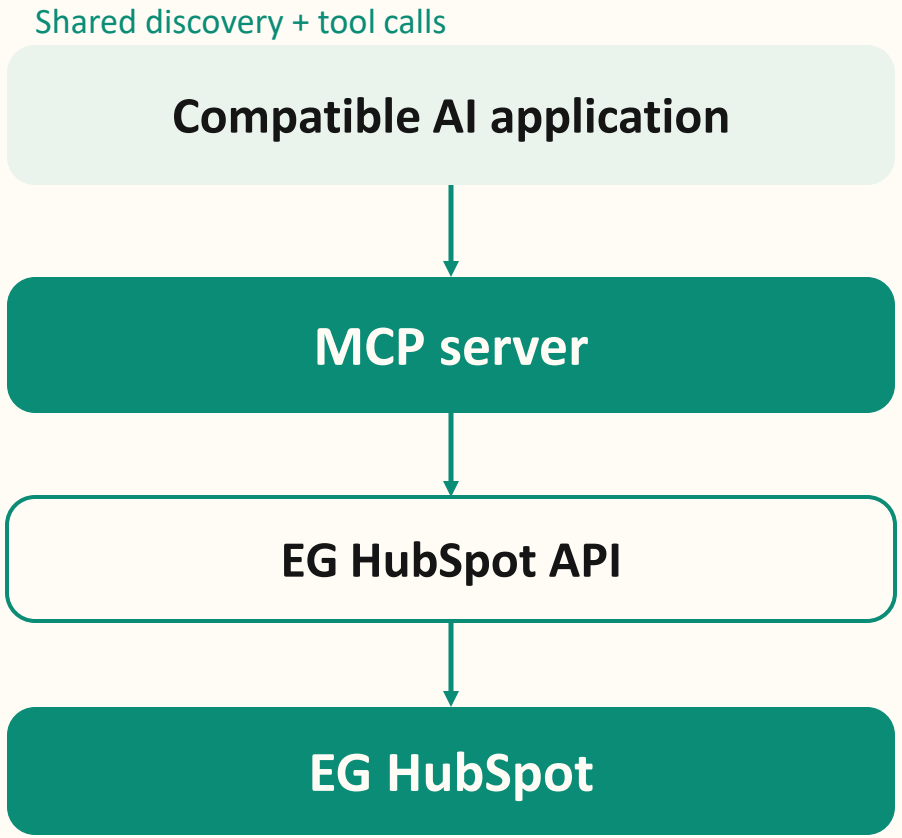


MCP versus APIs: making connections model-friendly

Direct API connection

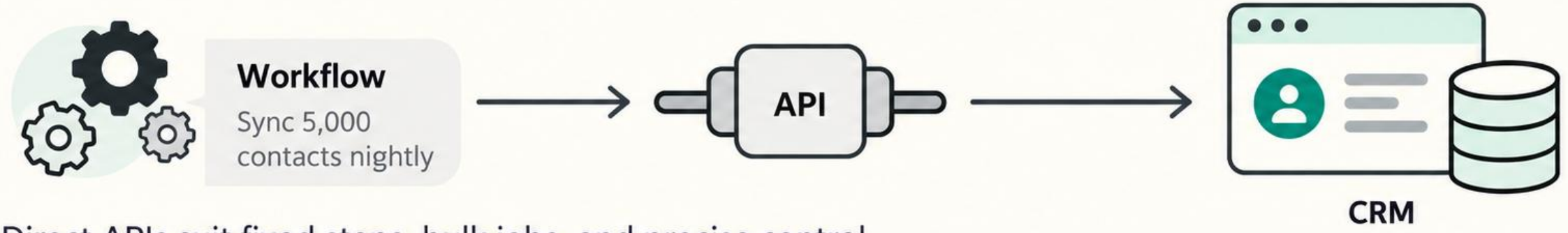


MCP connection

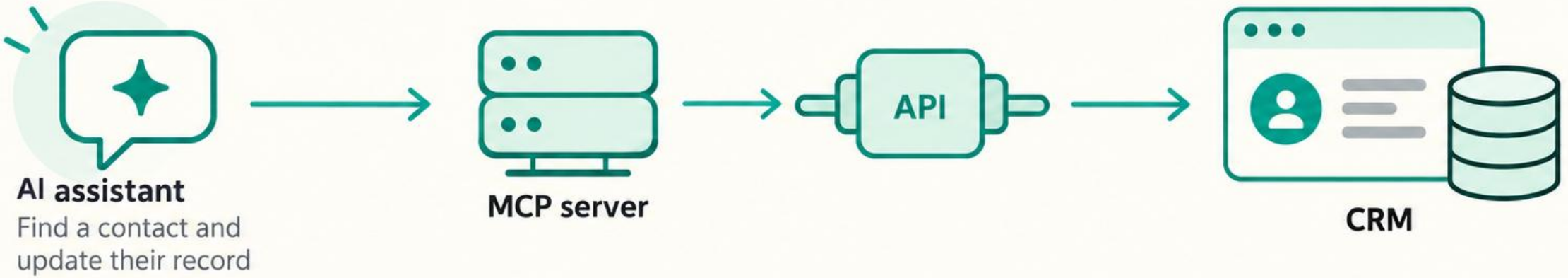


MCP vs. API

Two ways to connect to the same app.



Direct APIs suit fixed steps, bulk jobs, and precise control.



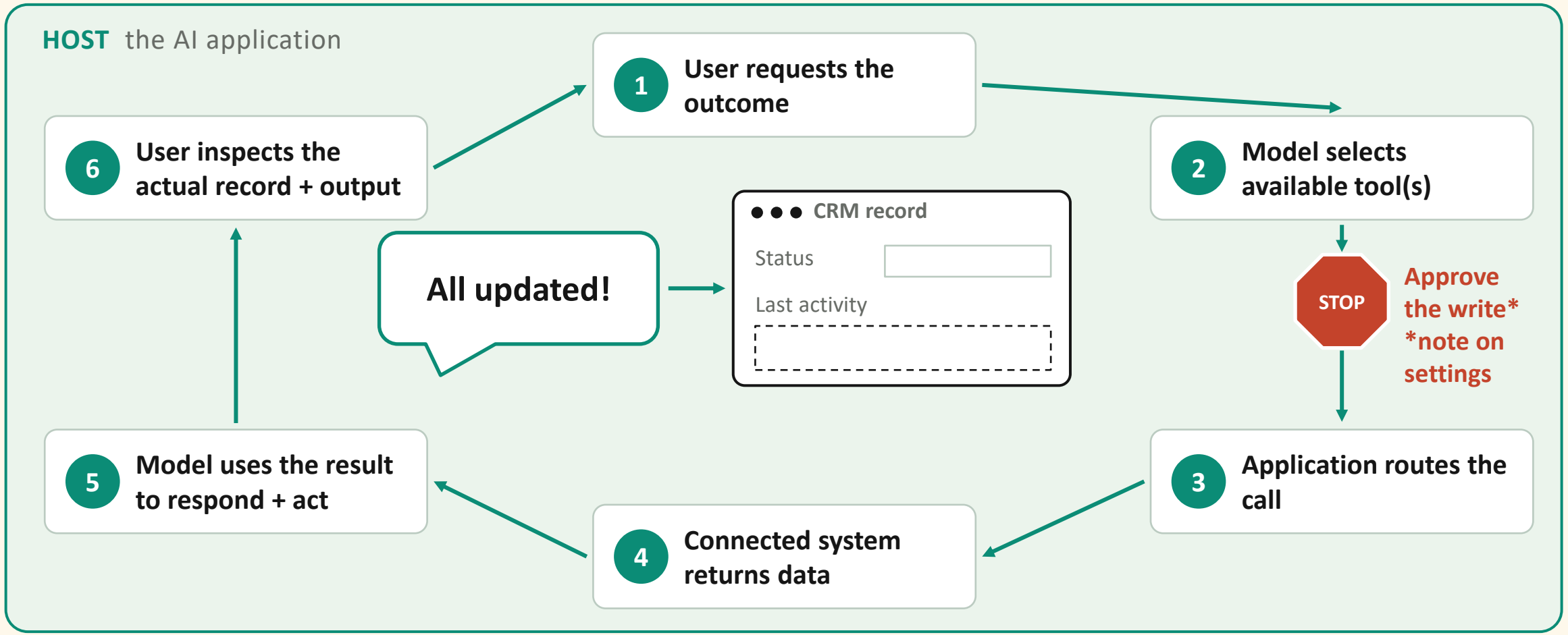
MCP gives AI a standard way to discover and use tools.

AI can use either. MCP often connects to the APIs underneath.

MCP = Model Context Protocol • API = Application Programming Interface

Example MCP workflow

The prompt: “Research this prospect”



RAG (Retrieval-augmented generation)

EVERYTHING YOU HAVE



RAG

retrieves what's relevant

Finds the right material first, then answers with it; can retrieve from:

- **PDF files**
- **Company manuals**
- **Company wikis**
- **Other external, more extensive knowledge sources**

Bounded capacity, measured in tokens

Agents: from answering to acting

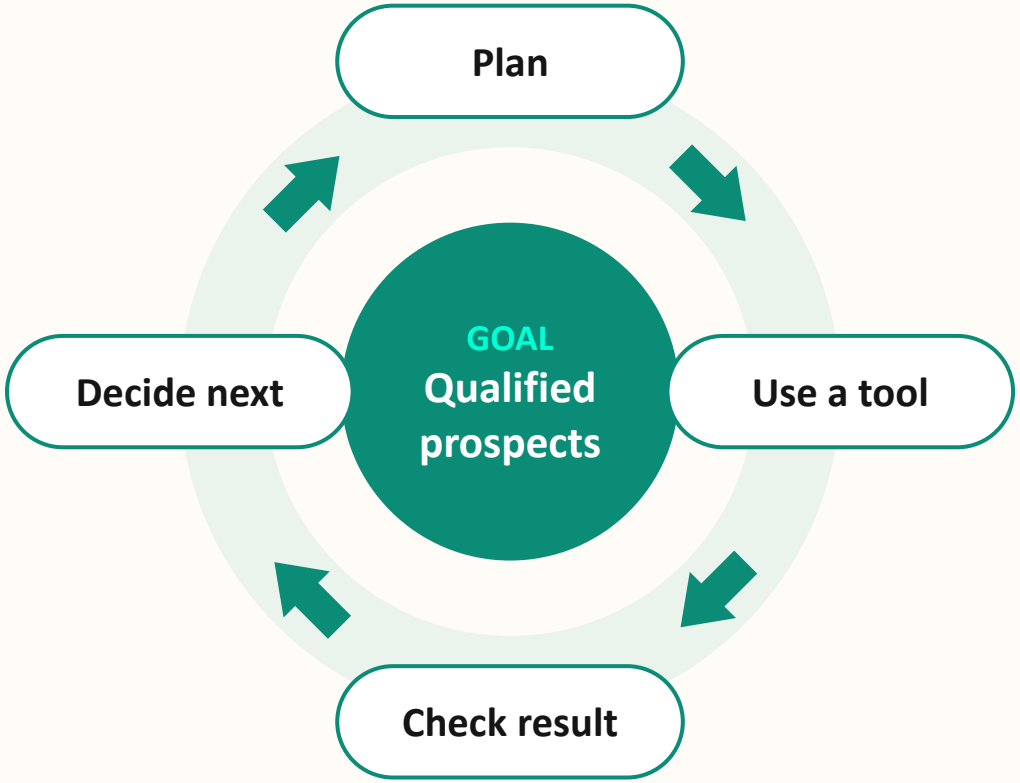
An agent is a model with a goal, tools it can use, and permissions to choose its next step until the goal is achieved.

Goal
What done looks like

Tools
MCP, API, Skills, RAG, A2A

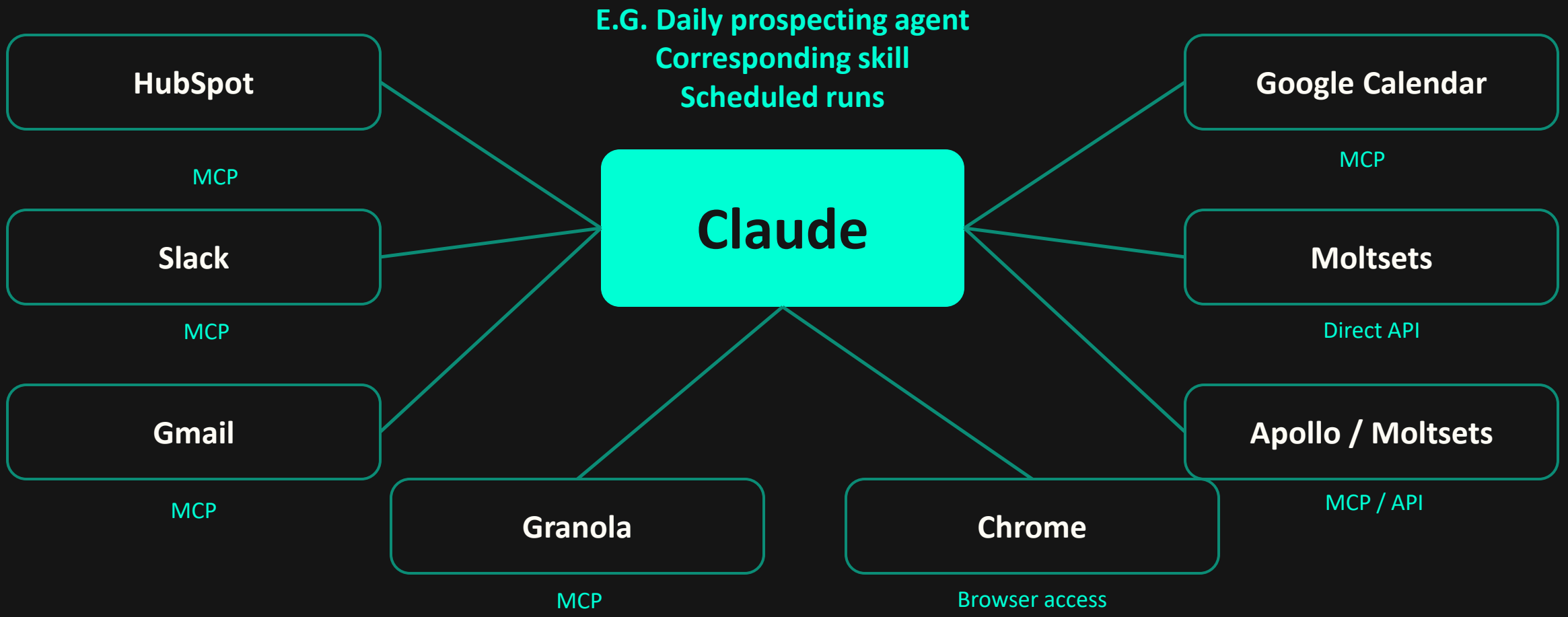
Loop
Plan, act, check, repeat

Guardrails
What it may do without asking

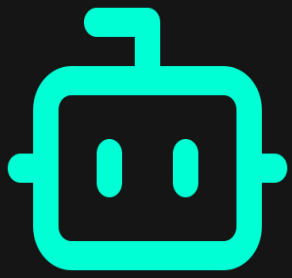


A2A (Agent2Agent) open protocol (Google 2025) | Linux Foundation | MCP connects an agent to tools; A2A connects agents to agents

My operations, connected: prospecting agent use case in action



Let’s see it all in action!



Going forward

01 What is worth connecting?

02 What actions can it take?

03 Who chooses the next step?



Let's keep Building!

Scan to connect on LinkedIn,
or email me what you build first.

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